One of Our Indian Teachers

Dr. C. F. Kuder

WHEN, in March, 1892, the writer, three months after his arrival on the field, took charge of the educational work of the Rajahmundry Mission, the transfer of one of the teachers to another station created a vacancy. At the time there was a fine youth in what was then the highest class in the school, there called the second Form, and corresponding about to the next to the highest class in the grammar school grade in this country. A deformed sister and a needy aunt were the other members of his family, and all were as poor as the traditional church mouse.

The thought came to me that this youth could be made a half-time teacher, leaving him free to attend classes the other half time, and thus solve two problems with one solution: get a teacher and provide support for the helpless relatives. The plan was put into operation and worked out splendidly. This youth was Mungamuri Devadas.

When the annual examinations were held, Devadas passed, and the school becoming a full Lower Secondary, as called there, he entered the final and highest class, out of which he passed successfully a year later, after which he was made a full-time teacher. Subsequently he was sent to the government normal school, completed the course and came back fully qualified according to the then existing requirements. During these years the Mission provided him with a house and an income sufficient to enable him and his relatives to live in comfort.

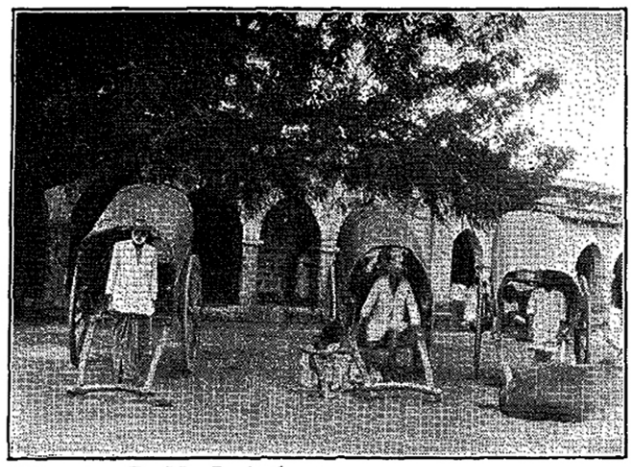
And with this educational development there was another going on—silently, steadily, persistently. That was his spiritual development. Living near my bungalow, he became my right-hand man, which involved oversight of the boys in their hovel-like boarding houses and assisting me in the translation of much needed religious textbooks. He derived a double advantage from this latter work: knowledge of English and a deeper acquaintance with religious truths; all of which he made fullest use of in later years. Perhaps his crowning work in this line was the composition of a triumphant Easter hymn, "Vijayamu," which became widely popular. And it is not too much to say that if one were to ask the hundreds of boys in school under his superintendence of their housing quarters, certainly ninety-nine out of every hundred would say that he was true to his name, Devadas: Sanskrit for servant of God.

When I left the Mission he was at Luthergiri as teacher and overseer of the dormitory, but during all the years he held these positions he grew in knowledge, and became one of the best public speakers and preachers in the Mission, a fact which led to a new sphere of activity during the past ten years.

The Rest of the Story

Amy Rohrer Neudoerffer

WHEN the station Boarding Schools were started and the Luthergiri Boarding School discontinued, Mr. Devadas became a teacher in the Bible Class at Luthergiri. As he was always a very welcome preacher among the high caste Hindus, he was made general evangelist among caste people in the Rajahmundry Mission. After his regular addresses, the Hindus would follow him to his place of lodging and talk with him until the early hours of morning. He was troubled much with asthma and the late hours told on his health. He finally developed tuberculosis.



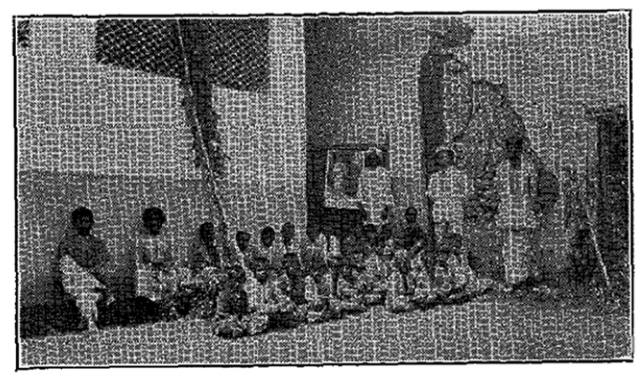
Taken by E. M. Springhorn

OX BANDIES WAITING TO TAKE THE STALL SCHOOL GIRLS HOME FOR THE CHRISTMAS VACATION

Many of his Indian friends tried to help him, but he finally became worse. One of the missionaries went to the village where he was staying with some relatives and persuaded him to go with him to the United Mission Tuberculosis Sanitarium at Madanapalli. He remained there for more than a year, and when he grew stronger, did much work as an evangelist among the patients. After his return to Rajahmundry he was again ill with asthma.

When the Tuberculosis Sanitarium was begun near Rajahmundry by the congregation of St. Paul's he took up his residence there and served as a sort of house father —at the same time doing some literary work. He was again in constant demand as a Bible teacher and preacher.

He is at present filling that position in the Sanitarium. Mr. Devadas has always stood head and shoulders above others in spiritual matters. A simple announcement that M. Devadas will speak at a meeting is always sure to draw a crowd. Christians and non-Christians never tire of him. He is a recognized spiritual leader.



CASTE BOYS' SCHOOL, PEDDAPURAM